NYC congestion pricing: where transit should improve next

Evidence from the first six months and a phased plan for outer-borough transit

October 2026

Congestion pricing is working; the next step is a phased transit pilot, starting in Eastern Queens

SITUATION

Congestion pricing is working. About 67,000 fewer vehicles a day (−11%) entered the zone in the first six months, and highway speeds across the city barely changed (median −0.37 mph).

COMPLICATION

Many outer-borough residents still lack a good alternative to driving. Modelled transit trips to Manhattan take 56–71 minutes, 13–22 of them walking and waiting, and key feeder buses are slow, unreliable or not measured at all.

RESOLUTION

Use toll-funded capital money where demand and a measured barrier overlap. Start in Eastern Queens, where a model test saves 6.2–12.5 minutes a trip (six Union Turnpike origins to Midtown East, 8 a.m.); follow with the East Bronx and Southeast Queens once their delays are measured.

Decision requested: approve Phase 1 in Eastern Queens (months 1–12, [$__M]) and fund delay measurement on the Bx8 and Q30 before any work in the Bronx.

Sources: MTA six-month tolling report (2025); NYC DOT speed data; Census LODES 2023, ACS 2018–2022; OpenTripPlanner journey model. Note: [$__M] = cost to be confirmed.

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Four questions this briefing answers

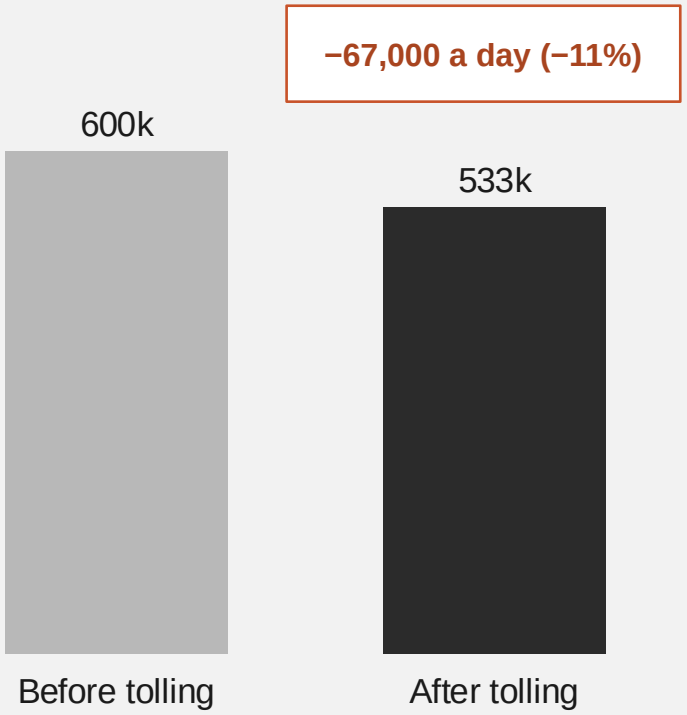
01	**What has congestion pricing changed so far?** Traffic into the zone, and who travels to Manhattan	Slides 4–5
02	**Where does transit still fall short, and why?** Candidate areas, door-to-door trips and missing bus data	Slides 6–8
03	**What should be built, and where?** A fix for each area and a model test on Union Turnpike	Slides 9–10
04	**In what order, and what is decided today?** Three-phase roadmap, decisions and next 90 days	Slides 11–12

Appendix: highway speeds after tolling (slide 13)

Congestion pricing cut daily vehicle entries into the zone by about 11% in its first six months

Vehicles entering Manhattan south of 60th Street. Official before/after estimate and 2025 weekday counts by crossing.

Daily vehicle entries (official estimate)



Where vehicles enter: average weekday entries by crossing, 2025



Busiest crossings

East 60th St	**79.5k**
FDR Drive	**53.0k**
Lincoln Tunnel	**46.8k**
Queens Midtown Tunnel	**46.5k**
West Side Highway	**45.9k**
Holland Tunnel	**41.4k**

Top two crossings carry 26% of entries

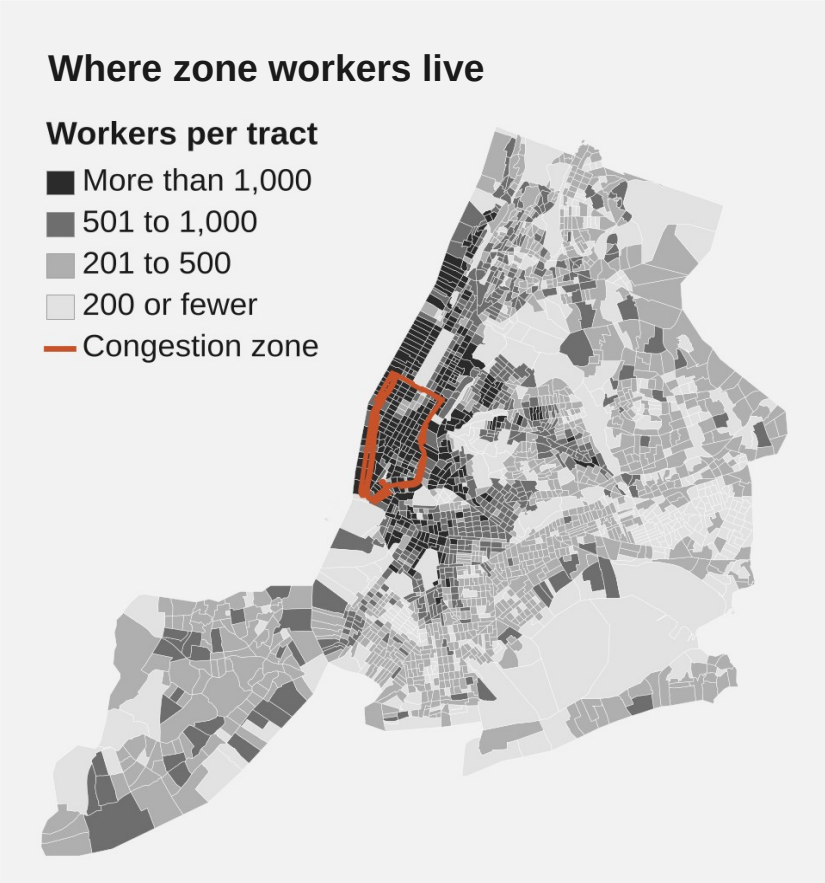
Circle size = weekday entries

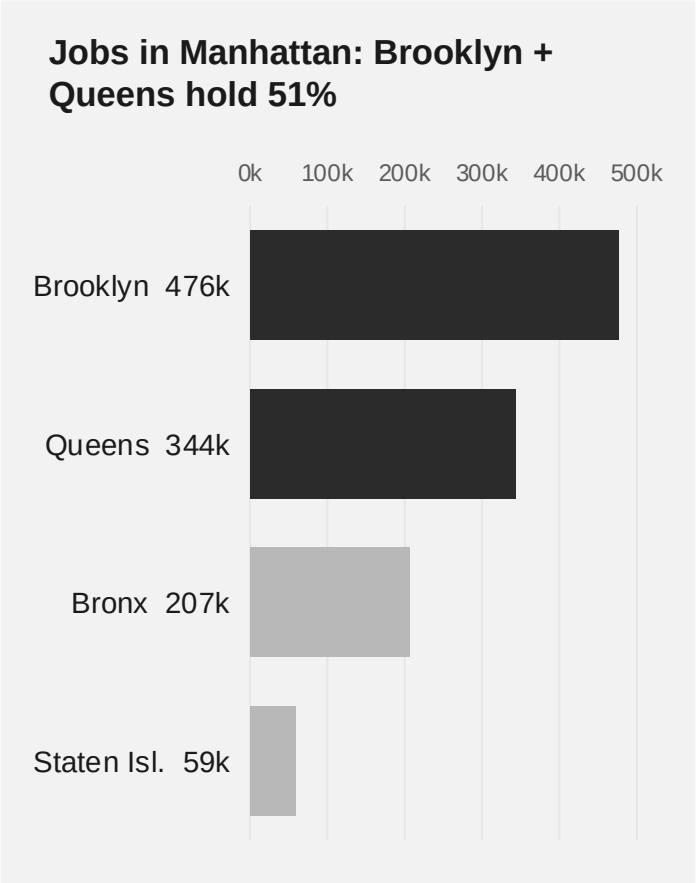
Sources: MTA six-month tolling report; NY Open Data t6yz-b64h (5 Jan–30 Jun 2025). Note: crossing counts (511,829 a weekday) use a different method and do not add up to the official totals.

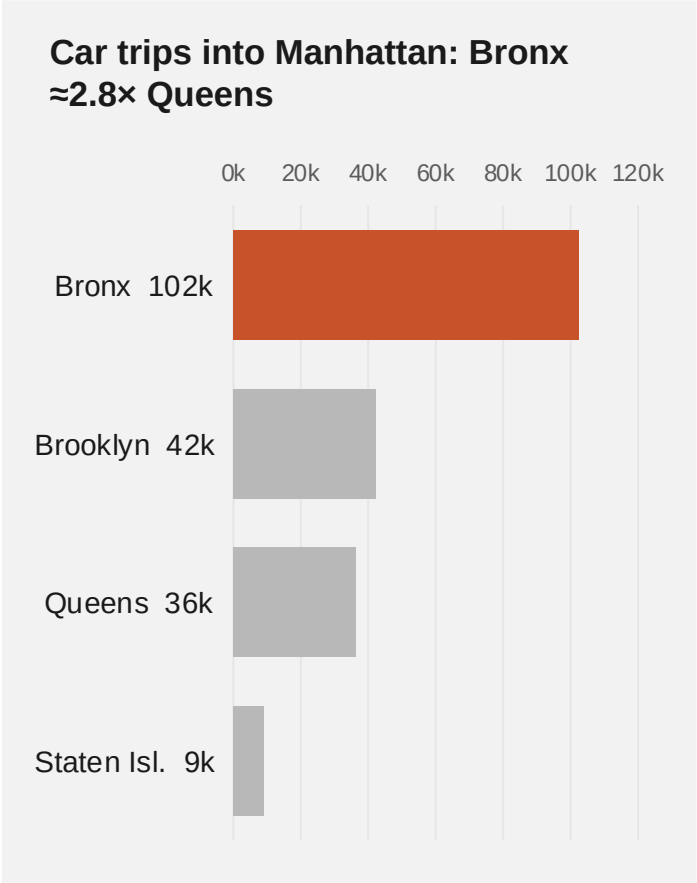
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Brooklyn and Queens hold most Manhattan jobs, but the Bronx makes the most car trips into Manhattan

Where zone workers live (Census, 2023), jobs in Manhattan by borough, and daily car-driver trips into Manhattan (city survey, 2024).





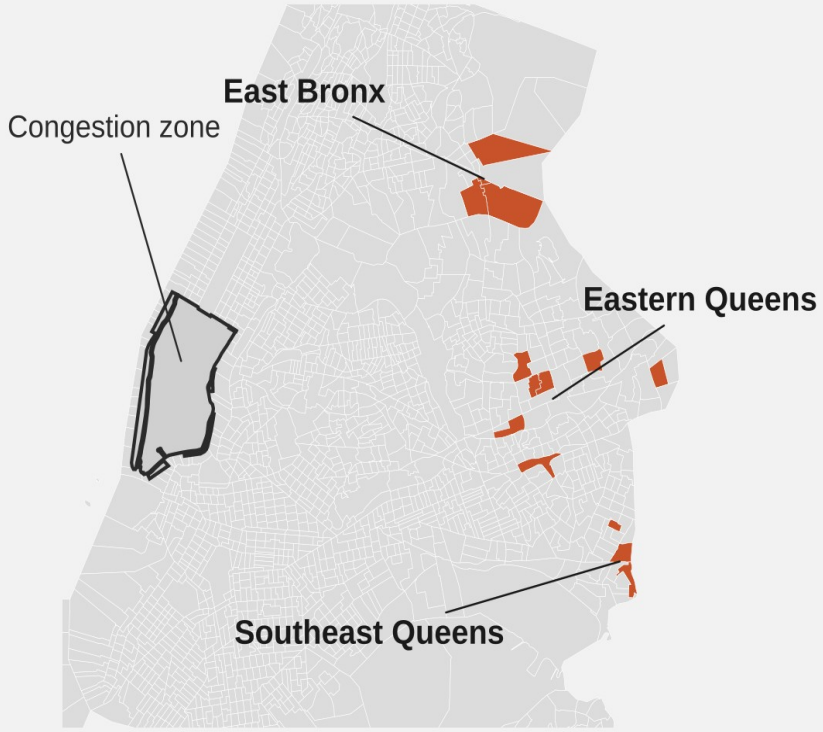


Sources: Census LEHD LODES 2023 (payroll jobs; Manhattan residents hold a further 532k); NYC DOT Citywide Mobility Survey 2024. Note: survey trips go to all of Manhattan, not only the zone.

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Three areas combine car use, Manhattan jobs and slow transit; Eastern Queens has the most jobs, the East Bronx the most driving

Matched census tracts in each area. These are places to test, not proven hotspots of drivers.



Area	Jobs in the zone	Drive alone	Transit trip and main barrier
Eastern Queens Union Tpke / Fresh Meadows	2,649 (28%)	30–60% (avg. ~42%)	55.6 min; long walks to the bus
East Bronx Throggs Neck / Pelham Bay	1,454 (29%)	50–81% (avg. ~57%)	71.2 min; 16-min feeder bus
Southeast Queens Rosedale / Laurelton	651 (27%)	50–60% (avg. ~53%)	61.9 min; outdoor transfer and 2nd fare

Strongest case on demand
Eastern Queens: 2,649 zone jobs, almost twice the East Bronx.

Strongest case on car use
East Bronx: 57% drive alone, but its bus delay is not yet measured.

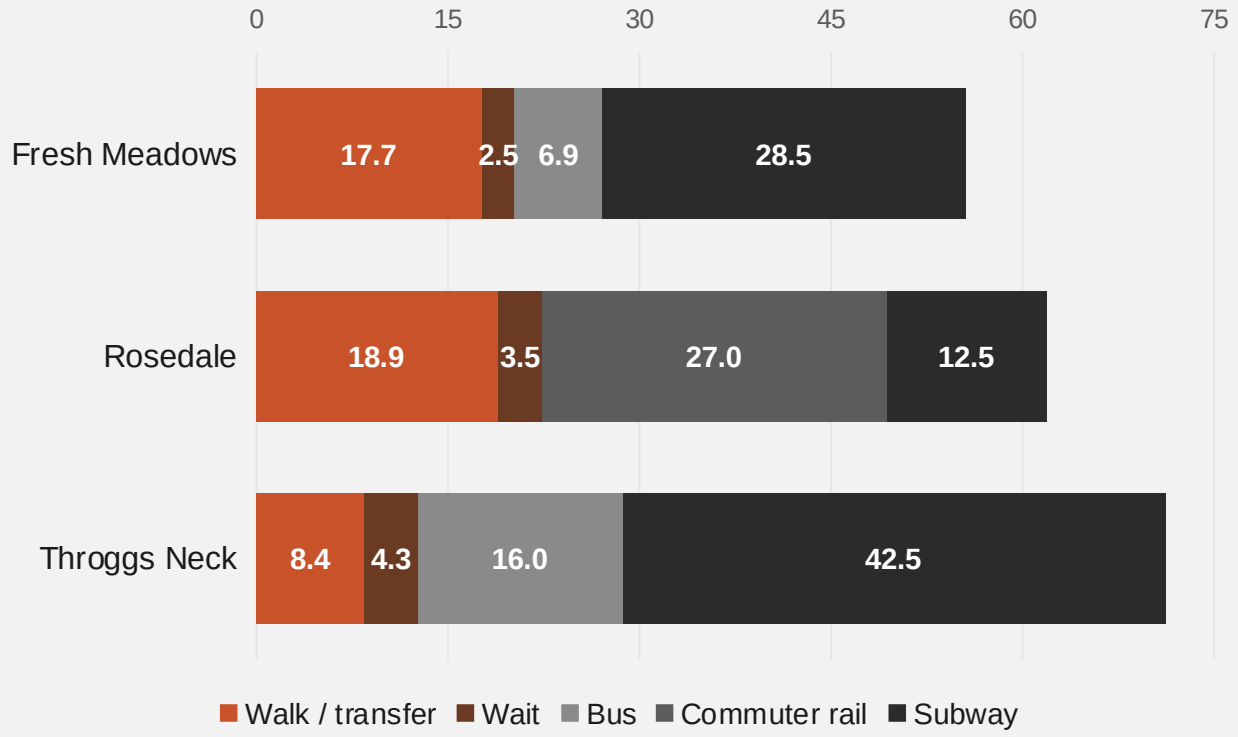
Sources: Census LODES 2023; ACS 2018–2022; OpenTripPlanner journeys M01, M02, M07. Note: jobs show where workers live, not who drives in; drive-alone rates cover all commutes.

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Transit trips take about an hour, and walking and waiting add about 13–22 minutes to each

Modelled trips on the fall 2026 schedule, leaving 8 a.m. on a Wednesday. Not observed commute times.

Where the time goes (minutes)



Fresh Meadows → Midtown East **55.6 min**

Walk and wait: 20.2 min

17.7 min is walking. The Q30 ride is only 6.9 min, so bus lanes alone won't fix it.

Rosedale → Lower Manhattan **61.9 min**

Walk and wait: 22.4 min

LIRR is fast (27 min), but the Nostrand Ave transfer adds an outdoor walk and a second fare.

Throggs Neck → Grand Central **71.2 min**

Walk and wait: 12.7 min

The Bx8 bus takes 16 min on Crosby Ave; its real speed is not yet measured.

Source: OpenTripPlanner v2 with MTA fall 2026 schedules (OTP_VERIFIED_10_OD_ITINERARIES.csv, trips M01, M02, M07). Note: driving times not shown because they are not calibrated.

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The two feeder buses that matter most, the Q30 and Bx8, have never been measured

MTA bus data, weekday mornings, August 2026. What we know about nearby Queens routes, and what is missing.

Queens routes we can measure: average morning speed (mph)



Q46 is the Union Turnpike feeder in our model test, and the fastest of these routes.

Q58 arrives on time 66% of the time, below MTA's 70% target.

Not measured yet

Q30
Fresh Meadows feeder to the F train
Speed: unknown · On time: unknown

Bx8
Throggs Neck feeder to the 6 train
Speed: unknown · On time: unknown

What to do: collect speed and on-time data on both routes before committing capital money to bus lanes.

Sources: NY Open Data kufs-yh3x (MTA bus segment speeds, Aug 2026, Mon–Fri 7–9 a.m.); MTA bus wait assessment (scheduled gap + 3 min). Note: Q30 and Bx8 are not among the 29 routes in the dataset.

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Each area needs a different fix; the two Eastern Queens projects are ready to start first

One main barrier and one main fix per place. Evidence for each is in the speaker notes.

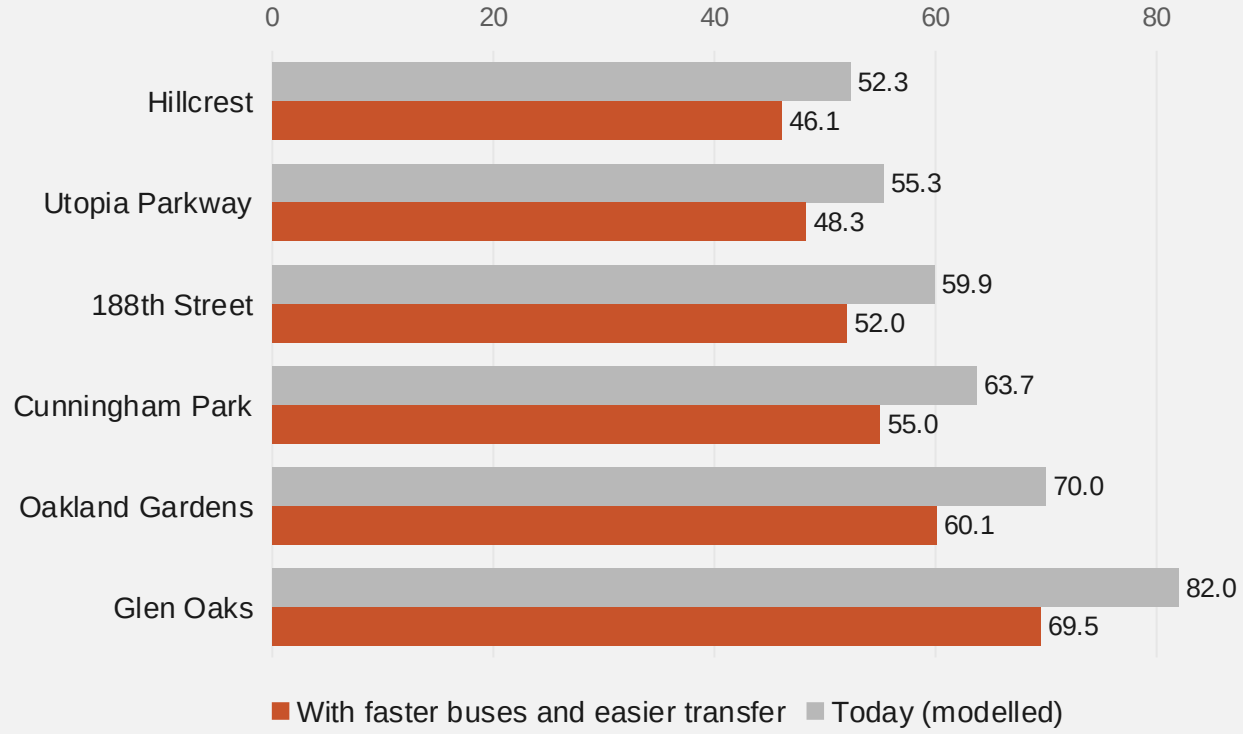
Place	Main barrier	What to build	Cost	Phase
Fresh Meadows Eastern Queens	Long walks to the bus	Safer, shorter walks to Q30 stops; better shelters	[$__M]	1
Union Turnpike Eastern Queens	Slow feeder bus and transfer	Q46 bus lanes and signal priority; sheltered transfer at Kew Gardens	[$__M]	1
Throggs Neck East Bronx	16-minute feeder bus	Measure Bx8 delays, then a bus lane on Crosby Ave	[$__M]	2
Rosedale Southeast Queens	Outdoor transfer and a 2nd fare	Covered LIRR–A train link at Nostrand Ave; cheaper transfer fare	[$__M]	2

Sources: Census LODES 2023 and ACS 2018–2022; OpenTripPlanner journeys M01, M02, M07; Stage 5 scenario model. Note: [$__M] = cost estimate to be confirmed with MTA and NYC DOT.

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From Union Turnpike to Midtown East at 8 a.m., faster buses and easier transfers save 6.2–12.5 minutes in a model test

Six origins along Union Turnpike to Midtown East. A what-if model, not a ridership forecast.



8.7 min

average time saved per trip (13.5%)

Where the saving comes from

- Faster buses (+30% speed): 3.2–9.5 min
- Easier transfer: 3.0 min on every trip

Read with care

Trips still take 46–70 min. Covers the Q46 only, not Fresh Meadows walking.

Source: Stage 5 scenario model (stage5_od_scenario_results.csv); OpenTripPlanner baselines. Note: assumes the Q46 runs 30% faster and transfers take 3 min less.

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Roll out in three phases, starting in Eastern Queens because it is the most ready to build

Each phase starts only when the previous one passes its review.

	Phase 1 · Eastern Queens Months 1–12	Phase 2 · East Bronx and SE Queens Months 12–24	Phase 3 · Measure and scale Months 24–36
Actions	Q46 bus lanes and signal priority; Fresh Meadows walk and shelter fixes; tap-to-pay at Kew Gardens; count real car trips into the zone	Crosby Ave bus lane (if Bx8 delay is confirmed); covered transfer at Nostrand Ave; test a cheaper LIRR-to-subway fare	Expand bus priority to more corridors if drivers switched; link buses to future IBX stations; report to the MTA Board
Proposed lead	NYC DOT (streets); MTA Bus	NYC DOT; MTA Construction & Development; LIRR	MTA; NYC DOT
Budget	[$__M]	[$__M]	[$__M]
Review before next phase	Trip times and ridership up, car entries from the area down, compared with a control road	Same measures; Bx8 delay confirmed before building	—

Why Eastern Queens first: the most zone jobs (2,649) and a road wide enough for bus lanes now. The East Bronx is more car-dependent (57% drive alone), so it follows as soon as Bx8 delays are measured.

Sources: NY Public Authorities Law §553-j; MTA 2025–2029 Capital Program. Note: leads are proposed; [$__M] budgets to be confirmed.

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Three decisions today would let work start within 90 days

Decisions requested from this meeting, and the first actions that follow.

DECISIONS REQUESTED

01 **Approve Phase 1 in Eastern Queens**

Q46 bus priority, Fresh Meadows walk access and the Kew Gardens transfer. Budget [$__M].

02 **Fund delay measurement on the Bx8 and Q30**

Speed and on-time data before any construction in the Bronx.

03 **Agree how success is judged**

Five measures and a control road (Hillside Ave), reported to the MTA Board.

NEXT 90 DAYS

Action	Proposed lead	Timing
Start speed and on-time tracking on the Bx8 and Q30	MTA Bus	Month 1
Design Q46 bus lanes and signal priority on Union Tpke	NYC DOT	Months 1–3
Audit walking routes to Q30 stops in Fresh Meadows	NYC DOT	Months 1–2
Baseline counts: ridership, car entries, control road	MTA; NYC DOT	Months 1–3
Confirm capital eligibility and cost estimates	MTA Capital Program	Months 2–3

Note: leads and timings are proposals for discussion; [$__M] budgets to be confirmed.

Highway speeds barely changed overall; the biggest slowdown came during roadwork

80 links with good data (of 122 monitored), weekday mornings 7–10 a.m., March–June 2024 vs 2025.



Faster by more than 2 mph	**13 links**
Little change (within 2 mph)	**45 links**
Slower by more than 2 mph	**22 links**

−0.37 mph median change across the 80 links

BQE southbound: 42.2 → 21.5 mph (−49%). Deck repairs were under way; this data cannot show the cause.

No citywide gridlock, and no fix for local bottlenecks.

Source: NYC DOT traffic speed data (Socrata i4gi-tjb9), 86 weekdays per year; links kept only with at least 65 good days in both years.

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